# Memory Is Not Enough: Separating Drift from Background Conflict in Continual Document Understanding

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## Abstract

*We study catastrophic forgetting in continual key-information extraction: replaying a few hundred stored documents comes close to joint training on average when the extractor meets new domains, yet fails when its label space grows. We treat this failure as an investigation rather than a method. On one class-incremental stream of receipts, with one encoder for every control, we test a ladder of hypotheses, state what each predicts before reporting its test, and measure where the errors go. First, forgetting is not simply harder: with a whole-document memory and a shared softmax, the model barely learns its last sessions, which naive training learns well. Then, true stored labels suffice to explain nearly all of it: giving every stored document its true labels before each session, an oracle no continual learner has, brings the same shared softmax to within* 2.4 *points of joint training on every seed (*92.1 *against* 92.0 *full-label F1), whereas a softmax slice of the replay loss, which leaves the stale "O" targets in place, recovers only 19 to 29% of the gap. Without true labels, a MiB-style unbiased loss recovers about half of it, and one background logit per session, as in existing readouts, closes most of it:* 89.1 *full-label F1 with the same memory (*88.4 *with raw documents). This readout implements a principle from training on partially annotated data: an "O" label is evidence only against the classes its annotator could see. Finally, on one schema, per-session low-rank trunk updates can replace the memory; across schemas they did not, in one run.*

## 1. Introduction

Key-information extraction (KIE) labels each OCR token of a visually-rich document (form, invoice, receipt) using its words, its 2-D layout and the page image, and multimodal encoders such as LayoutLMv3 [13], LiLT [37] and BROS [11] define the state of the art. However, deployed extractors meet new document types and growing schemas, while retraining on all history is blocked by cost and by privacy constraints. This is a continual-learning (CL) problem, whose central obstacle is catastrophic forgetting [24].

There exist many CL methods to cope with forgetting, and replay is empirically the strongest [23, 38]. On documents, it looks sufficient at first: under one fixed label space, replaying a few hundred stored documents keeps LayoutLMv3 close to joint training on every seed (legacy protocol; Appendix E). However, when the label space grows session by session, replay ends far below joint training (Tab. 3; legacy protocol, which favours replay; Sec. 3), and our ports of distillation, prompts, low-rank adapters and the continual-NER methods built for the shift of the "O" label do no better under the same protocol. A class-incremental stream is expected to be harder. Nevertheless, difficulty alone does not explain why a memory that holds the old documents with their labels does not help. This hints that the failure lies in how the stored supervision interacts with that of the current session.

In this work, we treat this question as an investigation (Tab. 1): for each explanation a reader would offer, we state what it predicts before reporting its test, run an intervention on the same encoder, stream and recipe, and measure where the errors go (Fig. 2). First, forgetting is not just harder (H0): with a whole-document memory that retains under domain shift, the model suppresses its last sessions, which naive training does not do. Then, true stored labels suffice to explain nearly all of the failure (H1): relabelling every stored document before each session, an oracle, brings the shared softmax to within 2.4 points of joint training on every seed, although the current documents still call old entities "O"

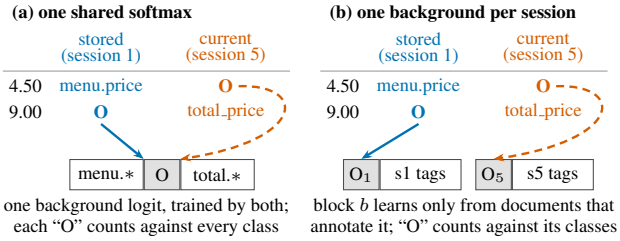



Figure 1. **The background conflict on one pair of price tokens.** A receipt stored in session 1 labels its total "O"; a current receipt of session 5 labels its item price "O". (a) With one shared softmax both "O" labels train the same background logit, against every class. (b) With one background per session (blocks 1 and 5 shown, each with its session's tags), an "O" is evidence only against the classes its annotator could see.

(H2). Without true labels, a MiB-style unbiased loss recovers about half of the full-label gap, whereas removing the shared background (H3, Fig. 1) closes most of it, given a memory. Finally, per-session isolation can replace the memory (H4), but only where label growth supplies a routing key.

None of the ingredients is new. The background shift is known from class-incremental segmentation [4, 6, 7], incremental detection [21, 27] and continual NER [22, 28, 43], and separated or per-session softmaxes [1, 14, 20] already undo the shared normalisation. However, to our knowledge, no prior work takes apart, on token-labelled documents, which part of the failure a memory repairs and which survives true stored labels. The contributions of our study are as follows: (1) we decompose why replay fails under label growth with a memory $\times$ readout factorial, relabelled memories that isolate the stored-label side, and where the errors go under each readout (Sec. 4); (2) we report an empirical finding, not a new mechanism: a per-session background readout, as in ICE-O and MORE, combined with whole-document replay and a supervision rule in the spirit of training on disjoint tag sets, closes most of the gap to joint training in continual KIE on every seed, where the continual-NER and replay methods in our comparison do not; it works with a raw or a latent memory, and the latent one is within 1.7 full-label points of raw documents on every seed while keeping no pixels or token ids (Secs. 5 and 6); (3) we delimit when the memory can go: with the conflict removed, per-session low-rank trunk deltas (SBR-Recall) replace the memory on one schema, within 2.1 points of joint training on every seed under both metrics, and fail without a memory across schemas (one seed), where the task-identity view says they must (Sec. 5.3); on images, which have no background class, the latent memory is competitive with raw replay while SLCA and RanPAC lead (Appendix F).

## 2. Related Work

Related studies fall into three groups: background shift, separated readouts and continual document IE.

**Background shift.** When each step annotates only its own classes, the background label changes meaning. In class-incremental segmentation MiB [4] lets a background label mean background or any old class in the loss, and the old model's background mean background or any new class in the distillation; PLOP [7] and SSUL [6] pseudo-label the background with the old model. Incremental detection has named both its stored side [21] and its two-sided form [27]. In continual NER the shift of "O" is the unlabelled-entity problem [22], answered by distillation on "O" tokens [28] and pseudo-labels [43]. We do not claim the conflict; instead, we separate its stored and current sides with relabelled memories and an unbiased loss and measure what each leaves.

**Separated readouts and task identity.** A softmax over old and new classes together biases them, and separating it removes the bias [1]; ER-ACE [3] masks the old classes out of the softmax of incoming samples. A "none of mine" output per task turns class-incremental learning into within-task prediction plus task identification [15]. MORE [14] isolates each task's parameters and trains each head's out-of-distribution output from saved samples; ICE-O [20], on a frozen encoder with no memory, trains one softmax per session over a constant Other logit. SBR is this pattern with a learned background per session and old blocks kept trainable from a memory; SBR-Recall shares MORE's isolation, by low-rank trunk deltas, with no saved samples.

**Continual document IE.** Document-level continual learning is recent and small: multimodal LLMs forget under fine-tuning [42], GDI-Bench [18] freezes most parameters, continual table detection [26] uses plain ER, ProtoNER [17] uses prototypes and AMD-Proj [33] projects gradients against task subspaces. Recently, Sassioui et al. [34] benchmarked layout-aware models by stream regime and found that no method they test consistently preserves old knowledge under label-space shift. However, they decompose forgetting by regime, whereas we decompose it by cause. Our memory is a form of latent replay [9, 29] that keeps whole documents; the broader CL families are surveyed by Wang et al. [38].

## 3. Setup

**Streams and models.** A document is its OCR tokens, normalised boxes and page image; the model emits BIO tags per token, scored by entity-level F1 (`seqeval`). We consider three streams (Tab. 2; sessions in Appendix A). Appendices A to F are in the supplementary material. **CIL-CORD**, the stream of every rung: CORD's 30 receipt classes arrive six at a time over five sessions; the head grows, and every entity outside the session, earlier or later, is labelled "O". **DIL**: FUNSD→SROIE→CORD under one fixed four-entity schema. **Mixed**: six sessions over three datasets and annotation schemas. LayoutLMv3-base [13] is the encoder of every rung; LiLT [37], BROS [11] and BERT appear on DIL.

**Memory and comparison set.** Unless stated, a memory is CoLaR (Sec. 5.2): 50 documents per session stored as rank-128 SVDs of their layer-4 activations. We benchmark against two references (naive fine-tuning, joint training) and eight methods from five families (Tab. 3): ER [32], DER++ [2], LwF [19], CODA-Prompt [35], CL-LoRA [10], LCA [36], and the continual-NER methods CPFD [43] and IS3 [30] (Appendix C).

**Protocol.** We use AdamW, learning rate $5\times10^{-5}$ (LCA: its own SGD recipe; Appendix C), batch size 2 and seeds 42,

Table 1. **The hypothesis ladder** (CIL-CORD, LayoutLMv3 unless stated; mean ± s.d. over three seeds, per-seed values when fewer; $^{n=k}$: $k$ seeds so far; $^{\dagger}$legacy protocol; "–": no full-label run). Verdict words: Sec. 4. $^{r}$True labels for the documents stored before the session just finished, at each boundary, or for every stored document before each session (Sec. 4.2). $^{e}$ER also trains every layer and keeps 200 raw documents, so it changes more than the memory format (Sec. 4.1). $^{w}$Trains every layer, where the CoLaR rows freeze the embeddings and layers 1..4. The pre-session row of H1 also tests H2: it leaves every current document stale.

| Rung | Hypothesis | Prediction if true | Intervention (CIL-CORD unless stated) | Full-label F1 | AA | Verdict |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | | | Naive fine-tuning (reference) | 13.0±0.2 | 18.3±0.5 | |
| H0 | Only drift: forgetting is just harder | a memory that retains under domain shift retains here; raw beats compressed | whole-document memory (CoLaR), shared softmax | 30.7±1.5 | 33.5±1.0 | refutes |
| | | | raw-document memory (ER), shared softmax$^{e}$ | – | 24.3±2.4$^{\dagger}$ | refutes |
| | | | raw-document memory, blocked readout$^{w}$ | 88.4±1.0 | 88.4±1.1 | does not support |
| H1 | Stale labels in the memory | true labels in the stored documents close the gap | older stored documents relabelled at each boundary$^{r}$ | 76.5±2.3 | 63.6±1.9 | partly |
| | | | every stored document relabelled before each session$^{r}$ | 92.1±1.3 | 91.3±1.3 | supports |
| H2 | Current documents mislabel old entities | a loss that lets "O" mean "O or an old class" closes the gap | replay and current losses sliced to their classes | – | 60.5±10.1$^{\dagger}$ | open |
| | | | MiB-style unbiased CE, both directions | 60.0±1.2 | 72.1±1.9 | partly |
| | | | replay softmax sliced, stale "O" kept | 45.9±1.6 | 48.8±8.2 | partly |
| H3 | The shared background normalisation | one background per session closes the gap without true labels, given a memory | CoLaR memory, session-blocked readout (CoLaR-SBR) | 89.1±2.0 | 88.4±2.6 | supports |
| | | | session-blocked readout, no memory | 11.4±2.3 | 21.6±2.2 | supports |
| | | | CoLaR memory, blocked readout with a constant background logit | 82.4±6.9 | 80.2±8.1 | partly |
| H4 | Isolation replaces memory where a routing key exists | per-session deltas need no memory on one schema, and fail across schemas | per-session deltas, blocked readout, no memory (SBR-Recall) | 92.6±1.0 | 91.9±0.6 | supports |
| | | | ICE-O (our port): frozen encoder, head per session, no memory | 57.0±0.7 | 35.2±0.7 | partly |
| | | | the same on Mixed (AA), no memory | – | 44.7$^{\dagger,n=1}$ | supports |
| | | | the same on Mixed (AA), 50-document memory | – | 85.9$^{\dagger,n=1}$ | supports |
| | | | Joint training (reference) | 92.0±0.4 | 91.3±0.8 | |

7 and 123; memory runs replay four stored documents per current batch of two. Under the *clean protocol* every session trains in full precision for at most 10 epochs (joint training: 100) and early-stops on 10% held out from its *training* data; the test split never selects a model. Cells marked † come from earlier runs (*legacy protocol*) that early-stop on the test split and vary in epoch cap and precision. A cell is clean only when all three clean seeds exist (Appendix A).

**Scoring.** Our headline number is the *full-label F1*: the final model on the complete CORD test set with all 30 classes, as in continual NER [22]. Only clean runs record it; against a cell with only AA (†, DIL, Mixed) we compare in AA. Retention needs per-session test splits, whose labels show only that session's classes; from $R[i, j]$, the F1 on session $j$ after session $i$, AA $= \frac{1}{T}\sum_j R[T, j]$. Since raw scoring of such labels charges a model for every correct entity of another

Table 2. **Benchmark settings** (sessions: Appendix A). Train/test documents: FUNSD 149/50, SROIE 626/347, CORD 800/100. AA: mean F1 of the final model over the sessions; full-label F1: on the unmasked CORD test set (Sec. 3).

| | CIL-CORD | DIL | Mixed |
|---|---|---|---|
| Datasets | CORD | FUNSD, SROIE, CORD in turn | FUNSD, SROIE, CORD |
| Sessions | 5 | 3 | 6 |
| Label space | grows, 6 per session | fixed, unified | grows, 3 schemas |
| Classes (BIO tags) | 30 (61) | 4 (9) | 12 (25) |
| At a boundary | new classes | new domain | new classes, domain or schema |
| Reported | full-label F1, AA | AA | AA |

session, we score each session *session-restricted*, mapping a predicted tag outside session $j$'s label set to "O" before span matching. On every seed both metrics order the main groups of clean runs the same way (Appendix A). Finally, tuning and evaluating on the same scenario overstates CL methods [5]: the comparison set was fixed after a first grid on all three streams, the memory settings were chosen on DIL, SBR's claim threshold (0.5) was not tuned, and the one setting chosen on CIL-CORD is SBR-Recall's delta capacity (Appendices C and D).

## 4. The investigation

Every rung runs on CIL-CORD with LayoutLMv3 under the clean protocol and changes one thing against the run it is compared with, unless stated (H0's memory rows change several). Table 1 lists the rungs and Fig. 2 draws them. A verdict word is a sign statement over the three seeds, not a significance test (Sec. 8): on every seed, the prediction holds (*supports*), fails (*refutes*) or holds in part (*partly*); *does not support* means it does not hold on every seed, *not needed* that the gap closes without the factor, and *open* that only preliminary, cross-protocol evidence exists. The *blocked readout* (Sec. 5.1) gives each session's tags their own background logit and softmax, a *block*; a block's *claim* on a token is one minus its background probability, and the *owning block* of an entity is the block of its gold class.

### 4.1. H0: only harder forgetting

**Prediction.** We first hypothesize that label growth only makes drift harder. Then the memory that retains under domain shift would still retain here, a raw memory would do better, and the losses would look like naive forgetting, where old sessions are lost and the newest is learned well.

**Test and result: refuted.** The CoLaR memory comes within 2.2 AA points of joint training on DIL on every seed (means $87.8^{\dagger}$ against $88.7^{\dagger}$). However, on CIL-CORD with a shared softmax it reaches $30.7\pm1.5$ full-label F1 ($33.5\pm1.0$ AA) against $92.0\pm0.4$ ($91.3\pm0.8$). Raw documents do no better (ER, 24.3 $AA^{\dagger}$, below every CoLaR seed), but ER also trains every layer, keeps 200 documents and is a legacy run; the raw-memory comparison under the same readout is in Sec. 5.2. What separates the memory run from naive forgetting is the session being trained: its newest session ends at 2.0 to 16.0 F1, whereas naive training learns every session to at least 78.6 on every seed. The memory run also freezes layers 1..4 after the first session and replays four stored documents with each current batch of two; with the same freezing (and, with the memory, the same replay), the blocked readouts with and without the memory learn every session to at least 81.1 (per-seed minimum), so lost plasticity does not explain the suppression. It keeps part of the old sessions' spans where naive training keeps none (Appendix D).

**What it rules out, and what it leaves.** Hence, drift alone does not explain the failure: the memory that answers drift on DIL leaves the session being trained suppressed here, which naive training, with all of its drift, does not show. Nevertheless, drift is real: naive training keeps nothing of the old sessions, on a fixed label space every encoder forgets its earlier domains and replay, not EWC or LwF, repairs it; and under naive fine-tuning the drift is largest near the output on all four encoders (Appendix E).

### 4.2. H1: stale labels in the memory

**Prediction.** We next hypothesize that the stored labels are stale. A document stored at session $t$ carries "O" on every entity of another session, earlier or later, so the memory itself calls background what the model must keep or learn; in detection, the same staleness of replayed examples was named foreground shift and blamed for replay's failure [21]. If they are the cause, true stored labels should close the gap with the shared softmax unchanged.

**Test.** We refresh the stored labels at two points. First, *at each boundary*, every document stored *before* the session just finished receives the true labels of all classes seen so far; that session's own documents keep their labels until the next boundary, and no such refresh covers the session trained next. Then, *before each session*, every stored document receives the true labels of all classes in the head grown for that session, so no stored label is stale while a session trains; the current documents still call old entities "O". Both read labels no continual learner has and are diagnostics, not methods.

**Result: partly at the boundary, supported before each session.** At the boundary, the refresh lifts full-label F1 from 30.7 to 76.5 (means, three seeds), 72 to 79% of the seed-matched gap to joint training, and stays below CoLaR-SBR under both metrics; it cannot reach the session being trained, whose classes are "O" in every stored document

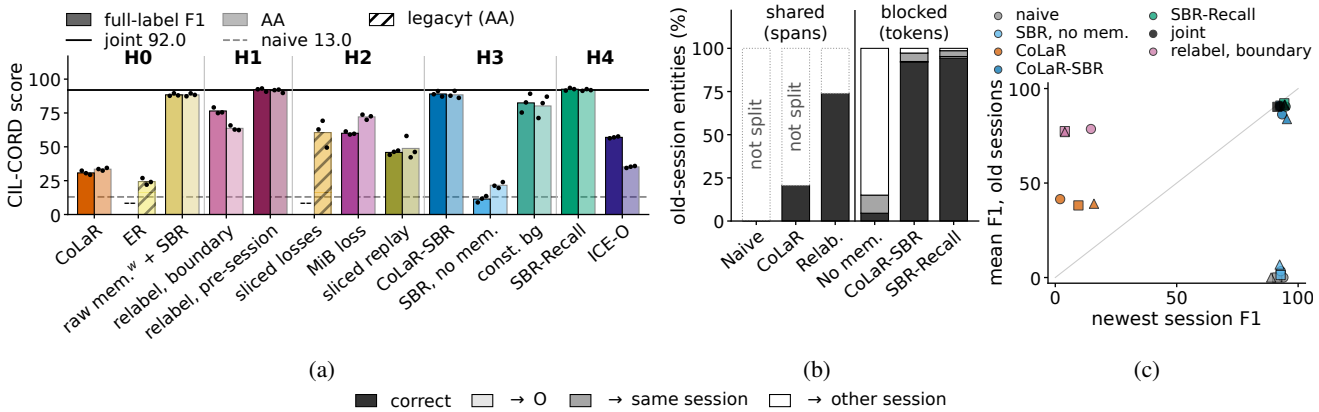



Figure 2. **The findings in one figure** (CIL-CORD, LayoutLMv3, clean protocol unless marked). (a) The ladder (Tab. 1): full-label F1 (dark) and AA (light); bar: mean of three seeds, dots: seeds; hatched: legacy (†), AA only; "–": no full-label run; lines: joint and naive full-label F1; $^w$trains every layer (Tab. 1). (b) Where the final model puts old-session gold entities (sessions 1 to 4, mean over seeds); a shared softmax records only span recall. (c) Per seed (circle: 42, square: 7, triangle: 123), newest-session F1 against mean old-session F1: with a shared softmax and a memory the newest session is suppressed; naive training learns it and keeps nothing older.

(Appendix D). In contrast, refreshed before each session, the same memory with the same shared softmax reaches 92.1±1.3 full-label F1, within 2.4 points of joint training on every seed under both metrics and above CoLaR-SBR on every seed (Tab. 1). As a result, true stored labels suffice to explain nearly all of the failure of replay under a shared softmax, on the session being trained as much as on old ones (three seeds); the control is an oracle, and its refresh also adds labels for the current classes (H2 tests label-free repairs).

### 4.3. H2: the current documents' "O" labels

**Prediction.** We then hypothesize that the current documents are the cause: each labels every entity of an earlier session "O", so even a memory with true labels is opposed in every batch by documents that call the same strings background; this is the second side of the conflict named in detection [27]. If this pull is the cause, a loss that lets a current "O" mean "O or an earlier class", as MiB does for segmentation [4] and marginal-likelihood taggers do offline [8], should close the gap within a shared softmax.

**Test.** We use the never-stale memory of H1, which leaves every current document stale, and two label-free repairs with the memory and the shared softmax. The first is MiB's unbiased cross-entropy in both directions: a current "O" token matches "O" or any earlier-session class, a replayed one "O" or any class introduced after storage (no distillation). The second slices each stored document's replay loss to the classes that existed when it was stored: later classes are no longer pushed down, but its stale tokens still train the shared "O" logit.

**Result: not needed, and a loss repair only partly helps.** With true stored labels the gap closes although every current document still calls old entities "O" (H1); hence the current side is not needed to explain the failure. The MiB-style loss lifts full-label F1 to 60.0±1.2, 46 to 49% of the seed-matched gap, above CoLaR and below joint training on every seed under both metrics, and below CoLaR-SBR on every seed. It removes the suppression of the session being trained, but the first session ends low. The softmax slice reaches only 45.9±1.6 full-label F1 (19 to 29% of the gap), above CoLaR and below the MiB-style loss on every seed under both metrics, and trains unstably (Appendix D). Hence a softmax slice does not recover the oracle's gain; whether removing the stale tokens altogether would is untested.

### 4.4. H3: the shared normalisation

**Prediction.** We hypothesize that the conflict lives in the shared normalisation, one background logit trained by documents that disagree about what is background. Then one background logit per session, normalised with that session's tags only, should close most of the gap with no true labels. This is SS-IL's diagnosis of a shared softmax [1] with a background added, and ICE-O's readout [20] without its frozen encoder. It needs the memory, since separating the labels does not undo drift; thus without a memory the same readout should fail, and fail the way drift does.

**Result: supported, on every seed.** With the memory, the blocked readout (CoLaR-SBR, Sec. 5.1) reaches 89.1±2.0 full-label F1, 0.6 to 5.3 points below joint training per seed, above the memory relabelled at each boundary and below the memory relabelled before each session on every seed, under both metrics. Without the memory, the same readout

scores 11.4±2.3, and its errors differ: old blocks on a drifted trunk claim far more than their own entities (Appendix D); that is drift, and the memory reduces it.

**What goes against it.** It is neither the only repair nor the best one: true stored labels before each session do better (Sec. 4.2), but the blocked readout needs none. The readout does nothing alone, and it is not free: on DIL, with nothing to separate, CoLaR-SBR is below CoLaR (AA $86.2^{\dagger}$ against $87.8^{\dagger}$).

**What discriminates what.** Drift (H0) is told apart from the label hypotheses by the session being trained: suppressed under a shared softmax with a memory, learned without one. We read the shared normalisation (H3) as the channel through which stale labels act, as negatives for every class; then separation should work even with a fixed background. With every background logit at zero, as in ICE-O, memory and blocked readout stay above CoLaR and below joint training on every seed under both metrics, recover most but not all of CoLaR-SBR's gain over CoLaR on seeds 42 and 7, and are above CoLaR-SBR on seed 123 (Tab. 1): the reading is partly supported; separation does most of the work, and the learned background adds to it on two of three seeds.

## 5. From diagnosis to design

**The principle.** The rungs point at one fact about annotation under label growth, familiar from training on partially annotated data [8]. A token marked "O" in session $s$ means "none of the classes annotated in session $s$": it is evidence against those classes and silent about every other. However, a shared softmax turns it into evidence against all classes, and a stale stored label makes the same error inside the memory. We therefore state one principle, which the per-session readout implements and H3 supports, partly as an explanation (Sec. 4.4): *supervise each class only with negatives from documents that annotated it, and normalise together only classes that were annotated together.* Three consequences follow: each session needs its own background; the memory must keep whole documents with their labels and the session that wrote them; and each session's background logit, trained on that session's true negatives, is also a detector of its entities, so it can route a token without task identity.

### 5.1. SBR: one background per session

SBR is our instantiation of a per-session background readout [14, 20] (Fig. 3b). Every session that brings new tags opens a block $b$ holding those tags $\mathcal{T}_b$. Whereas a shared softmax normalises over $\{\mathrm{O}\} \cup \bigcup_b \mathcal{T}_b$, SBR gives every session its own background logit $o_b(x) = w_b^\top h(x) + c_b$ on the token feature $h(x)$ and normalises each block separately:

$$p_b(\cdot \mid x) = \mathrm{softmax}\big([\, o_b(x),\, z_{\mathcal{T}_b}(x)\,]\big), \tag{1}$$

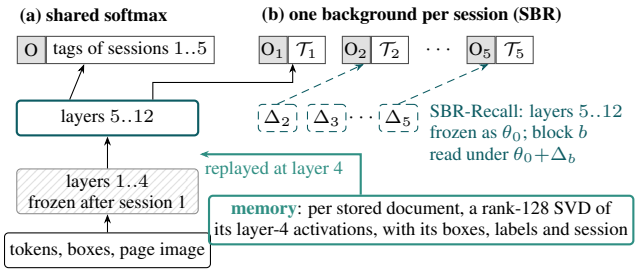



Figure 3. **The two readouts on one encoder and memory.** (a) One softmax over all tags and one background. (b) SBR: one background logit per session, trained only by documents that annotate it (Eq. (2)); the largest claim $e_b = 1 - p_b(\mathrm{O}_b) > 0.5$ labels the token. SBR-Recall drops the memory and reads block $b$ under its session's delta $\Delta_b$ (Eq. (3)).

where $z(x)$ are the tag logits of the usual linear head and $z_{\mathcal{T}_b}(x)$ its entries for the tags in $\mathcal{T}_b$. Within block $b$ a token labelled "O" in session-$b$ data is truly background, so the block's supervision is never stale. For a token $x$ with label $y$ in a document of session $s$,

$$\mathcal{L}(x, y, s) = \sum_b m_{sb}\ \mathrm{CE}\big(p_b(\cdot \mid x),\, y_b\big),$$
$$y_b = \begin{cases} y & y \in \mathcal{T}_b \\ \mathrm{O}_b & \text{otherwise,} \end{cases} \tag{2}$$

with one rule for the mask: $m_{sb}{=}1$ when session $s$ annotates every tag of $\mathcal{T}_b$; $m_{sb}{=}1$ with $y_b{=}\mathrm{O}_b$ when $b$ belongs to a different annotation schema (every token is a negative for $b$, a training-time convention; Appendix B); and $m_{sb}{=}0$ otherwise, because the document's "O" labels say nothing about block $b$. Stored documents follow the rule of the session that stored them. Since a session that adds no tags creates no block, SBR has a single block on a fixed label space. At inference each block reports its claim $e_b = 1 - p_b(\mathrm{O}_b \mid x)$; the block with the largest $e_b$ labels the token with its best tag if $e_b > 0.5$, and the token is "O" otherwise, as in ICE-O's "Other unless some session scores above it". Blocks trained at different times need not produce claims on one scale; hence we measure the routing directly (Fig. 2b).

### 5.2. The memory

SBR's supervision needs stored documents that keep each token's label at its position and the session that wrote it. CoLaR (Compressed Latent Replay) keeps whole documents: after the first session layers $1..k$ are frozen, and each stored document's layer-$k$ activations $H_j$ are kept as a rank-$r$ truncated SVD with its boxes, mask, labels and session, rebuilt at replay and injected at layer $k$; it holds no raw pixels or token ids (no privacy claim: activations can leak content). The memory format did not change the finding here (three seeds, CIL-CORD): raw documents under the same readout,

with the whole network trainable where CoLaR freezes the embeddings and layers 1..4, reach 88.4±1.0 full-label F1 against 89.1±2.0, seed-matched differences (raw minus latent) of −1.7 to +0.9 points (−1.9 to +2.2 in AA). We use CoLaR because it keeps no pixels or token ids (Sec. 6).

### 5.3. SBR-Recall: the test of H4

**Prediction (H4).** We hypothesize that, with the conflict removed, the memory is needed only against drift. The task-identity view [15] says when it can go: if each block is read under the trunk state that learned it, nothing drifts for that block, provided the model can tell which state a token belongs to. On one schema under label growth each block's background logit supplies that key. In contrast, across schemas the all-background terms of Eq. (2) train every old block towards background on other-schema documents with nothing to pull it back, so isolation should fail without stored documents; on a fixed label space there is one block and nothing to route by (not run).

**The intervention.** To test it, SBR-Recall freezes the layers above $k$ after the first session (the base $\theta_0$), stores for each later session $b$ a rank-64 delta $\Delta_b$ [12] of them ($\Delta_1{=}0$), and computes every term of Eq. (2) for block $b$, at training and test time, under the trunk state that learned it (Appendix B):

$$p_b(\cdot \mid x) = \mathrm{softmax}\left([\, o_b,\, z_{\mathcal{T}_b}\,]\right)\left(x;\, \theta_0 + \Delta_b\right). \qquad (3)$$

**Result: supported, with its predicted failure.** On CIL-CORD SBR-Recall reaches 92.6±1.0 full-label F1 (91.9±0.6 AA) with no stored document, within 2.1 points of joint training on every seed under both metrics, at the price of one inference pass per session (five on CIL-CORD; Appendix B). Our port of ICE-O (frozen encoder, one head per session over a constant Other logit, no memory) forgets nothing (final row within 0.3 points of its diagonal on every seed) and reaches 57.0±0.7 full-label F1 (35.2±0.7 AA), below SBR-Recall on every seed under both metrics; under our 10-epoch cap sessions 4 and 5 were still improving and session 3 early-stopped at 0.0 F1 on every seed, so this is a lower bound for ICE-O. On Mixed without a memory, SBR-Recall scores 44.7 AA$^{\dagger}$ (seed 42): as predicted, the blocks of the other schemas fall silent until their domain returns, and with the 50-document memory restored it scores 85.9 (Appendix D).

## 6. Ablations and memory cost

**Which component matters.** On the runs of Tab. 1 (supplementary Tab. 7, Appendix D) and on every seed, the memory alone raises full-label F1 over naive training by 16.3 to 19.2 points, and the blocked readout alone moves it by −4.3 to +0.7; together they raise it by 74.1 to 78.4, more than the two alone add up to, so the gain is an interaction, not a sum.

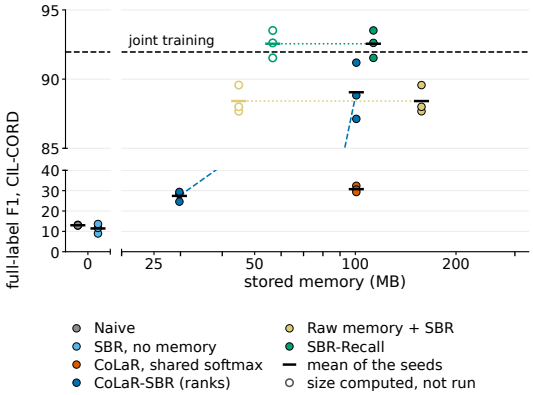



Figure 4. **Accuracy against stored bytes** (CIL-CORD, clean protocol; dots: seeds, bar: their mean). Bytes: what a method keeps across sessions; joint training keeps every document. Filled: the size the run held; hollow: the same run's size computed for an encoding it never ran in (raw documents with 8-bit pixels, SBR-Recall's deltas at two bytes per parameter); a dotted line joins the two sizes of one run, a dashed line CoLaR-SBR at ranks 32 and 128. Sizes: supplementary Tab. 5.

With raw documents in place of the latent memory (whole network trainable) the finding did not change: raw is neither above nor below CoLaR-SBR on every seed. Per-session deltas in place of the memory are above CoLaR-SBR under both metrics. True labels without the blocked readout fall below CoLaR-SBR when refreshed at the boundaries and above it before each session (Sec. 4.2).

**What the memory costs.** CoLaR stores 402.7 KB per document (100.7 MB for the 250 documents of CIL-CORD; Fig. 4), 2.8× less than the fp16 layer-4 activations it compresses. Raw replay keeps 630.8 KB per document as our code holds it, with fp32 pixels and int64 ids and boxes (157.7 MB), and would take 44.8 MB with 8-bit pixels. SBR-Recall keeps one delta per session instead: 28.3 MB in fp32 as trained (113.2 MB in all), or 14.2 MB (56.6 MB) at two bytes per parameter, a reporting choice that no run evaluated.

Above a compression floor, bytes do not separate the methods; the readout does: every store we ran at full rank (rank-128 latent or raw documents, or deltas) ends within 5.3 full-label points of joint training on every seed through the learned-background blocked readout, and the same latent bytes under a shared softmax stay at 30.7±1.5. At rank 128 CoLaR saves no bytes: it is 2.2× larger than raw documents with 8-bit pixels, and 1.6× smaller only against raw documents as our code holds them. What it gives instead is a whole-document memory without pixels or token ids; latent replay needs the frozen lower layers, so it trains 45% of the parameters our raw run trains (a raw memory could freeze the same layers), with full-label F1 within 1.7 points of raw replay on every seed (Sec. 5.2). The rank is the one knob

Table 3. **Benchmark results on LayoutLMv3**, grouped by family. Memory: what a method keeps (sizes on CIL-CORD; SBR-Recall at two bytes per parameter, half its fp32 size). Readout: one shared softmax or one block per session. Mean ± s.d. over three seeds, per-seed values when fewer; "–": not run. $^{\dagger}$legacy protocol; $^{n=k}$: $k$ clean seeds so far; $^{c}$one fp16 LwF seed that collapsed to all-background is excluded; $^{b}$with the 50-document memory; $^{p}$made before we fixed our port's orthogonality penalty. Ports and protocols: Appendix C.

| | | | | CIL-CORD | | Mixed | DIL |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Family** | **Method** | **Memory (what is stored)** | **Readout** | full-label F1 | AA | AA | AA |
| Reference | Naive fine-tuning | none | shared | 13.0±0.2 | 18.3±0.5 | 44.4/43.7$^{\dagger}$ | 41.3±1.5$^{\dagger}$ |
| | Joint training | all data, all sessions | shared | 92.0±0.4 | 91.3±0.8 | 86.9/88.5$^{\dagger}$ | 88.7±1.1$^{\dagger}$ |
| Regularisation | LwF (2016) | previous model | shared | – | 18.4/18.5$^{\dagger,c}$ | 47.7$^{\dagger,c}$ | 43.7±1.1$^{\dagger}$ |
| Replay | ER (2019) | 200 raw documents | shared | – | 24.3±2.4$^{\dagger}$ | 75.6/73.3$^{\dagger}$ | 87.9±1.4$^{\dagger}$ |
| | DER++ (2020) | 200 raw documents + logits | shared | – | 20.4±1.4$^{\dagger}$ | 75.1/74.0$^{\dagger}$ | 88.0±0.9$^{\dagger}$ |
| Prompt, LoRA | CODA-Prompt (2023) | none (prompt pool) | shared | – | 14.0/15.9$^{\dagger}$ | 12.1/10.6$^{\dagger}$ | 32.5±1.2$^{\dagger}$ |
| | CL-LoRA (2025) | previous model, past adapter matrices | shared | – | 18.7/18.6$^{\dagger}$ | 45.7/43.9$^{\dagger}$ | 41.1±0.3$^{\dagger,p}$ |
| Continual NER | CPFD (2023) | previous model | shared | – | 2.7/0.0$^{\dagger}$ | 0.3/15.1$^{\dagger}$ | 6.1±7.3$^{\dagger}$ |
| | IS3 (2024) | previous model, class prototypes | shared | – | 5.6/7.7$^{\dagger}$ | 0.0/40.6$^{\dagger}$ | 38.3$^{\dagger}$ |
| Merging | LCA (2026) | base and per-session backbones, class Gaussians | shared | – | 13.7/7.0$^{\dagger}$ | 38.0/36.4$^{\dagger}$ | 43.9±2.5$^{\dagger}$ |
| This paper | CoLaR | 50 docs/session, rank-128 layer-4 latents (100.7 MB) | shared | 30.7±1.5 | 33.5±1.0 | 75.6/74.6$^{\dagger}$ | 87.8±0.5$^{\dagger}$ |
| | **CoLaR-SBR** | 50 docs/session, rank-128 layer-4 latents (100.7 MB) | blocked | 89.1±2.0 | 88.4±2.6 | **89.1±0.6** | 86.2±1.3$^{\dagger}$ |
| | + LexSlot head slots | + head slots, token ids | blocked | – | 89.7±0.5$^{\dagger}$ | 89.6±1.0$^{\dagger}$ | 87.0±0.4$^{\dagger}$ |
| | **SBR-Recall** | one rank-64 trunk delta per session (56.6 MB) | blocked, per delta | **92.6±1.0** | **91.9±0.6** | 85.9$^{\dagger,b}$ | – |

that sets its size, but at rank 32 (29.8 MB) CoLaR-SBR falls to 27.4±2.5 full-label F1, 60.5 to 62.6 points below rank 128 and below plain CoLaR in full-label F1 on every seed; rank 64 is not evaluated. SBR-Recall's cost grows with the sessions, not their documents: it is cheaper only when a session's documents take more than its delta.

## 7. Evidence beyond one stream

**The comparison set.** On CIL-CORD every shared-softmax method of Tab. 3 stays at or below CoLaR in AA (33.5). All baselines are our ports, none checked against published numbers; four end below naive training on every seed as they learn later sessions poorly (Appendix C). On Mixed, where both causes act, CoLaR-SBR reaches 89.1±0.6 AA under the clean protocol; joint training and ER have only legacy cells (87.7$^{\dagger}$ and 74.5$^{\dagger}$, two seeds each), so we do not rank the three. Beyond CIL-CORD, evidence is the blocked readout with a memory on Mixed (three clean seeds), drift and replay on DIL (four encoders, legacy) and SBR-Recall's failure across schemas (one seed); the H1 to H3 controls and the memory comparison are CIL-CORD only.

## 8. Limitations and conclusion

**Limitations.** Our study covers three English datasets with test sets of 50 to 347 documents and four encoder-only backbones; the ladder's controls ran on LayoutLMv3 and one class-incremental partition of CORD only (Sec. 7). Every control rests on three training seeds and one test set of 100 CORD receipts: "on every seed" states the same sign on all three, not significance; differences under about two points (raw against latent memory, the constant background against the learned one on seed 123, the oracle above CoLaR-SBR) are not resolved, and the replay ratio (four stored documents per current batch of two), on which the size of the suppression may depend, was not varied. SBR-Recall on Mixed, the design-choice ablations and the image probe are single- or few-seed diagnostics. We did not run several comparators from this literature (among them PLOP, BPF, MiB's distillation and per-class sigmoid heads; Sec. 4.3). Joint training is a reference, not a bound, and ICE-O ran under our recipe, still improving at the epoch cap. SBR-Recall grows by a delta and a pass per session and freezes its base after session 1, so it may depend on session order. CoLaR's memory grows with the sessions and at rank 128 takes more bytes than raw documents with 8-bit pixels, while at rank 32, below that size, it loses most of its accuracy; storing no raw pixels or token ids is weaker than privacy.

**Conclusion.** In this paper, we investigated why replay fails in continual KIE when the label space grows. The experiments show that two things go wrong and a memory repairs only one, drift; the other, the background conflict, is removed almost entirely by true stored labels (an oracle, within 2.4 points of joint training on every seed), not by a softmax slice of the replay loss, and mostly by a per-session readout, which lets an "O" label count only against the classes its annotator could see. Without true labels, a MiB-style loss recovers about half of the full-label gap; where label growth supplies a routing key, on one schema, per-session deltas then replace the memory. We recommend testing continual document methods on a growing label space with a mask-free metric; next, we will run the ladder's controls on more streams and backbones.

## LLM Usage Statement

Claude (Anthropic), an LLM-based assistant, was used in this work to support running and monitoring experiments and to search and summarise related literature. All experiments were designed and decided by the authors, every reported number is produced by scripts from saved run files, and the authors reviewed and take full responsibility for all content.

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